

17-Year-Old Sienna Toohey Shatters Leisel Jones' Age Record

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To kick off the second night of Australian Swimming Trials, 17-year-old Sienna Toohey put together a statement swim. The Albury native threw down a 1:05.97 100 **breaststroke** to break an iconic age record and become the fastest Australian in the **post-supersuit era**. The 17-year-old age record previously belonged to all-time great Leisel Jones. She posted a 1:06.37 at the same age at the 2003 World Championships in Barcelona, which was a new world record at the time. Toohey had previously been nipping at that record's heels when she went her previous lifetime best of 1:06.43 at Australia's Age Championships in April. Tonight, Toohey distinguished herself from her old best and 17-year-old Jones with a blistering first 50 of 30.58. This made her too quick to catch on the second 50. She now moves into third all time among Aussies, and she surpasses Chelsea Hodges as the fastest post-supersuit swimmer from the nation. The swim also proves hopeful for Australia on the contemporary world stage. This season, she checks in as the 5th fastest performer. Among both **Commonwealth** and **Pan Pac** countries, which she has punched tickets for, she sits among the top three. A 1:05.97 100 breast would've qualified for the Paris 2024 and Singapore 2025 finals. Australia has not had an Olympic or Worlds **qualifier** in the event since 2019. On the women's **medley relay** front, if Toohey can replicate this speed, it places Australia as an even clearer world #2 behind the United States. At the 2025 World Championships, the Aussies earned the silver, about three seconds behind the Americans and two seconds ahead of China with Ella Ramsay on **breaststroke**. Ramsay also had a big swim of 1:06.70 for runner-up tonight, which is a new best for the 21-year-old. Sienna Toohey is definitely a name to watch.

Word Treasure

breaststroke -- A swimming stroke where the arms move in a half-circle in front and the legs kick like a frog.

post-supersuit era -- The period after 2010 when high-tech full-body swimsuits were banned, making times set now harder to compare with earlier records.

Commonwealth -- A group of countries, mostly former British colonies, that hold their own multi-sport event called the Commonwealth Games.

Pan Pac -- Short for Pan Pacific Championships, a swimming competition among nations bordering the Pacific Ocean.

medley relay -- A team race in swimming where four swimmers each use a different stroke: backstroke, breaststroke, butterfly, freestyle.

qualifier -- A swimmer who has met the time standard to take part in a major competition like the Olympics or World Championships.

Background you need

Leisel Jones is one of Australia's most decorated swimmers, having won nine Olympic medals (including three golds) and setting multiple world records in breaststroke.

The 'supersuit era' (2008-2009) saw dozens of world records fall due to full-body polyurethane suits; FINA banned them in 2010, so times set since are labeled 'post-supersuit' to indicate a more even playing field.

Sienna Toohey hails from Albury, a regional city on the New South Wales-Victoria border, showing that elite talent can emerge outside major metropolitan centers.

The Commonwealth Games and Pan Pacific Championships are two major international meets where Australia regularly competes against top swimming nations like the USA, Canada, and China.

Break it down

LEAD: 17-year-old Sienna Toohey makes a statement at the Australian Swimming Trials.

+ - specific: Swims 1:05.97 in the 100m breaststroke.

KEY EVENT: Breaks Leisel Jones' 17-year-old age record.

+ - OLD RECORD: Jones' 1:06.37 set at 2003 Worlds in Barcelona.

+ - HOW: Blistering first 50 (30.58) made her too quick to catch.

RANKINGS:

+ - Moves to third all-time Australian, fastest in post-supersuit era.

+ - Surpasses Chelsea Hodges.

GLOBAL CONTEXT:

+ - 5th fastest performer in the world this season.

+ - Top-3 among Commonwealth and Pan Pac countries.

+ - Time would have qualified for Paris 2024 and Singapore 2025 finals.

RELAY IMPLICATIONS:

+ - Could boost Australia to clearer world #2 in women's medley relay.

+ - 2025 Worlds: Australia won silver, 3 seconds behind USA, with Ramsay.

OTHER COMPETITOR: Ella Ramsay swam personal best 1:06.70 for runner-up.

OUTLOOK: Sienna Toohey is a name to watch.

Why it matters

Toohey's achievement shows that hard work and talent can rewrite records even at a young age, and it highlights how advances in training and fair equipment rules create space for new stars to emerge in competitive sports.

Test what you remember

1. What time did Sienna Toohey swim to break Leisel Jones' 17-year-old age record?
 - (A) 1:06.37
 - (B) 1:05.97
 - (C) 1:06.43
 - (D) 1:06.70
2. Where did Leisel Jones set the previous 17-year-old record in 2003?
 - (A) Australian Swimming Trials
 - (B) World Championships in Barcelona
 - (C) Olympic Games
 - (D) Commonwealth Games
3. What was Toohey's split for the first 50 meters of her race?
 - (A) 30.58 seconds
 - (B) 31.00 seconds
 - (C) 30.97 seconds
 - (D) 29.58 seconds
4. According to the article, Australia has not had an Olympic or World Championship qualifier in women's 100m breaststroke since when?
 - (A) 2010
 - (B) 2019
 - (C) 2023
 - (D) 2025
5. Who finished second in the race and also swam a personal best?
 - (A) Chelsea Hodges
 - (B) Leisel Jones
 - (C) Ella Ramsay
 - (D) Sienna Toohey
6. If Toohey replicates her speed on the women's medley relay, how might Australia rank?
 - (A) Clear world #1
 - (B) Clear world #2 behind USA
 - (C) Behind China and USA
 - (D) Below Canada

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: A 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive:** Fans celebrate Toohey's breakout swim as a sign that Australian women's breaststroke is regaining strength. Her time could bring medals in upcoming international meets.
- 2. Critical:** Some worry about the pressure placed on a teenager to keep delivering top performances, and note that comparing eras is tricky even after the supersuit ban due to other technological changes.
- 3. Neutral:** Historical comparisons are a useful way to measure progress, but swimming times are also influenced by pool technology, nutrition, and training science.
- 4. Forward-looking:** If Toohey maintains this trajectory, she could become a medal contender at the 2028 Olympics and spark new investment in youth swimming programs in regional Australia.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):